Launch plan

For you, the founder: the steps from today to a live demo, a first real shop, a priced and papered offer, and a trained salesperson. Work through it in order; each phase ends with a "done when" you can check.

At a glance

	Phase	Done when	Rough time*
1	**Business basics**	The business is registered, has a bank account and insurance quotes, and you know how you'll invoice.	Weeks 1–2
2	**Your domain and server**	**https://demo.yourbrand.com** is live, secure and resets every night.	Weeks 2–3
3	**Test it like a customer**	You've run every task in both guides on the live demo, from a phone, and restored a backup.	Week 3
4	**Pilot with one real shop**	One shop has used it for 6–8 weeks and you have before/after numbers and a testimonial.	Weeks 3–10
5	**Package, price and paperwork**	A price sheet, a service agreement and a pilot agreement, reviewed once by a lawyer.	During the pilot
6	**Sales kit**	Brochure, proposal, demo logins, a 10-minute demo script and answers to objections are ready.	Weeks 8–11
7	**Recruit and train a salesperson**	They've passed both knowledge checks and given two demos while you watched.	Week 12 on

*A guide for a solo founder working part-time. Phases 4 and 5 overlap; don't hire a salesperson before the pilot gives you real results to sell.

1 Business basics

Do these before you take money from anyone. Rules differ by state and country, so check locally: a local small-business development centre, a free mentoring service (in the US, the SBA and SCORE), or an accountant can tell you what applies to you in one meeting.

- [ ] **Name.** Pick a business and product name; check nobody else uses it for software (search the trademark register) and that the **.com** is free (section 2).
- [ ] **Register the business** (sole proprietor or a limited company / LLC). An LLC separates your personal assets from the business; ask an accountant which suits you.
- [ ] **Tax ID** (in the US an EIN, free from the IRS) and a **business bank account**. Keep business money separate from day one.
- [ ] **Bookkeeping**: a simple accounting app or spreadsheet for income, expenses and the server bills.

- [ ] **Insurance quotes**: general liability; **professional liability (errors and omissions)**, because shops will make ordering, pricing and allergen decisions with your software; and **cyber liability**, because you'll hold their sales, staff and pay data.
- [ ] **Getting paid**: invoices that accept card and bank transfer, with automatic monthly billing for subscriptions.

> **Not legal or tax advice**
> This plan lists what to sort out; a local professional should tell you how.

2 Your domain and server

One domain for everything: a subdomain per shop

Yes: buy one domain for your brand, and use it for the demo and for every customer. The app runs **one shop per copy**, so each shop gets its own copy at its own subdomain, with its own data, logins and backups. One shop can never see another's data, and a problem in one doesn't touch the rest.

Address	What it's for
demo.yourbrand.com	Sales demos: the sample juice bar, with demo logins, put back to the sample every night.
sunrise.yourbrand.com, **greenbar**.yourbrand.com …	One per paying (or pilot) shop. Starts empty; you load their menu.
yourbrand.com	Optional: a one-page website with the brochure and your contact details.
you@yourbrand.com	Business email on your domain. Customers and suppliers take it more seriously than a free address.

2.1 Buy the domain

- Short, easy to spell when said out loud, ideally **.com**. Any well-known registrar works (Cloudflare, Namecheap and Porkbun are common choices).
- Turn on **auto-renew**, **registrar lock** and **two-factor sign-in** on the registrar account. Losing the domain takes every customer offline.

2.2 Rent a small server

- A Linux virtual server (Ubuntu LTS) with **2 GB of memory** from any mainstream provider (DigitalOcean, Hetzner, Linode/Akamai, Vultr, AWS Lightsail…).
- Each shop uses about **50 MB of memory** (measured), so a 2 GB server should run the demo plus roughly 15–20 small shops. Watch memory and upgrade when it gets tight.
- Secure it on day one: sign in with **SSH keys** (not passwords), a firewall that only allows ports 22, 80 and 443, automatic security updates, and two-factor sign-in on the hosting account.

2.3 Point the domain at the server

In your registrar's DNS settings, add two **A records** pointing at the server's IP address: one for `demo`, and a wildcard `*`. With the wildcard, new shops need no DNS changes.

2.4 Start the demo

Install Docker on the server, copy this project onto it, put your domain into `deploy/multi/Caddyfile`, then:

```
cd deploy/multi
docker compose up -d --build
```

Caddy gets the HTTPS certificate by itself within a minute or two. The demo starts with the sample juice bar.

2.5 Create the accounts straight away

> **Do this before you share any link**
> On a brand-new copy, whoever opens it first can create the owner account. So create it yourself the moment a copy starts:

```
docker compose exec demo python -m app.auth add yourname owner       # asks for a password
docker compose exec demo python -m app.auth add demo-manager manager
docker compose exec demo python -m app.auth add demo-staff staff
```

Give your salesperson the demo-manager and demo-staff logins, never your owner login.

2.6 Reset the demo every night

So every demo starts clean, whatever was clicked the day before. On the server, run `crontab -e` and add:

```
15 3 * * *  /path/to/project/deploy/multi/reset-demo.sh >> /var/log/menu-demo-reset.log 2>&1
```

Demo logins and passwords are kept. Run the same script by hand just before an important demo.

2.7 Backups and monitoring

- [ ] Turn on the hosting provider's **weekly server snapshots**.
- [ ] Every week, download each shop's **full backup** (Settings → Backups) and keep it off the server. Shops also get automatic daily copies on the server.
- [ ] Add each address to an **uptime monitor** (several have free plans) so you hear about an outage before your customers do.
- [ ] Once, practise a **restore** on the demo (`python -m app.backup restore …`; see docs/HOSTING.md) so you know it works.

What it costs to run

Item	Rough cost*
Domain	about $10–25 a year
Server (2 GB), demo plus many shops	about $10–25 a month
Business email	about $5–8 per mailbox a month
Uptime monitoring	free plans available
Insurance, registration, lawyer review	varies: get quotes (section 1, 5)

*Typical prices at the time of writing; check current prices before you budget.

3 Test it like a customer

Before anyone else sees it, use the live demo exactly as a shop would. Fix or note anything that surprises you.

- [ ] On your phone, **on mobile data** (not your Wi-Fi), open https://demo.yourbrand.com. Check the padlock shows and the page loads quickly.
- [ ] Sign in as **staff** and do every task in the **Staff guide**: a sale, an allergy check, a delivery with one damaged item, a count, a waste entry, sign out.
- [ ] Sign in as **manager** and do every task in the **Manager guide**: reset a staff password, import a till file, create a purchase order, move a shift, read the variance report.
- [ ] Take both **knowledge checks** yourself without looking. Anything you get wrong, a customer will too: improve the guide.
- [ ] Get a **real till export** (from your pilot shop, a friend's café, or a free trial of Square, Toast or Clover) and import it. Check the columns and names match.
- [ ] Load a **real menu** through Excel: download the workbook from an empty copy, fill in Ingredients, Menu Items and Recipes, import it. Time how long it takes: that's your onboarding effort per shop.
- [ ] **Restore a backup** onto the demo (section 2.7).
- [ ] Try it on the **tablet** a shop would actually use at the counter and at the back door.

4 Pilot with one real shop

This is the most important step. A real shop's results are what you (and later your salesperson) will sell, in place of the illustrative estimate in the proposal.

Choose the shop

- Makes drinks or food to **recipes** from ingredients it buys (juice bar, smoothie or coffee shop, bakery café, small kitchen).
- One location; uses a **till system that exports item sales to CSV**.
- An owner who already feels the pain: waste, running out, not knowing their drink costs, ordering from memory.

Offer and agree

- Free or heavily discounted for **6–8 weeks**, in exchange for honest feedback, a weekly 20-minute check-in, a testimonial, and permission to use their before/after numbers (anonymously if they prefer).
- Put it in a one-page **pilot agreement** (section 5): dates, what you do, what they do, that their data is theirs, what happens at the end.

Measure before, then after

Measure	How to get it before the pilot
Food cost %	Last month's ingredient purchases ÷ sales (from invoices and the till).

Waste	Ask them to note what they throw away for one week.
Stock-outs	How many times a week something runs out ("86'd").
Time on admin	Hours a week spent counting, ordering and scheduling.

At the end, compare, write a one-page **case study**, and update the proposal and brochure with the real figures.

Set up a shop (repeat for every customer)

1. In `deploy/multi/docker-compose.yml`, copy the commented **customer template** block; rename it (e.g. `sunrise`) and its volume.
2. In the `Caddyfile`, copy the commented block with the same name. Run `docker compose up -d`.
3. **Immediately** create your owner account and the shop owner's account (section 2.5, with `sunrise` in place of `demo`).
4. Collect: menu and recipes, recent supplier invoices, staff list with pay rates, a sample till export.
5. Load the menu through the Excel template (section 3); set reorder points, par levels, yields and allergens; add staff; set the target food cost.
6. Train the owner with the Manager guide and staff with the Staff guide; have everyone take their knowledge check.
7. Check in weekly for the first month.

When a shop leaves: download their full backup and give it to them (it's their data), then remove their block and volume.

5 Package, price and paperwork

Decide the offer

A **one-time setup fee** (your onboarding time) plus a **monthly fee** (hosting, backups, updates, support) is easiest to explain. Keep what's included realistic for one person, as you did with the brochure: write it down so nobody, including a salesperson, promises more.

- **Setup**: decide what's included, e.g. "we load up to 40 menu items from your completed template and train your team in one session". Anything beyond is extra.
- **Support**: how customers reach you, your hours, and how fast you reply (e.g. "next business day").
- **Monthly price floor**: (your support hours per shop per month × your hourly rate) + server share + payment fees, then add a margin. Example: 2 hours × $40 + $2 server + $3 fees = $85 cost, so price comfortably above that.

Documents to have ready

Document	Covers

Service agreement	What you provide; fees and billing; term and cancellation; support hours and reply times; best-effort availability; **the customer owns their data** and gets a full export on leaving; backups; limit of liability; that costs, reorder suggestions and allergen lists depend on what the shop enters and don't replace their own allergen procedures.
Pilot agreement	A one-page version for the free or discounted trial (section 4).
Privacy notice	What personal data you hold (staff names, contact details, pay rates, sign-in records), why, where it's stored, who can see it, how long you keep it.
Salesperson agreement	Commission terms, what they may and may not promise, confidentiality, ending the arrangement (section 7).

Pay a lawyer once to review these as templates; it's far cheaper than fixing a dispute. Then update the proposal's pricing table to match.

6 Sales kit

Have all of this ready **before** you hire, so the salesperson sells the same thing you would.

- [ ] **Brochure** with your real contact details (fill in the placeholders in `docs/brochure/brochure.html`), printed on good paper.
- [ ] **Proposal** template updated with the pilot's real results and your price sheet.
- [ ] **Case study** from the pilot: one page, before/after numbers, a quote from the owner.
- [ ] **Demo logins** for the salesperson (demo-manager and demo-staff), and a tablet to demo on.
- [ ] **Demo script** (below), **qualifying questions** and **answers to objections** (next page).
- [ ] A simple **pipeline sheet**: shop, contact, till system, stage (contacted, demo booked, demo done, pilot, customer), next step and date.
- [ ] Two short **follow-up emails**: one the same day as a demo, one a week later.

The 10-minute demo

Time	Show	Say (in your words)
0–1	Ask, don't show	"How do you know what each drink costs you today? What happens when you run out of something mid-shift?"
1–3	Menu builder: open a drink	"Here's what this smoothie really costs, ingredient by ingredient, and the price that hits your target. Allergens come from the recipe."
3–4	Till import	"Each morning you load yesterday's sales from your till. Nobody types anything twice."
4–6	Dashboard → Procurement	"It tells you what's running low, before it runs out, and builds the order for each supplier."
6–7	Receiving	"Staff check deliveries off on the tablet: damaged or missing items are recorded, not paid for by surprise."
7–8	Counts & Waste	"A weekly count shows what went missing, in dollars."

8–9	Schedule	"Drag shifts around and see labor against sales."
9–10	Settings → Users; Excel	"Everyone has their own login; it's backed up daily; and it's all in Excel, which you keep." Then ask for a pilot or a follow-up.

Qualifying questions (is this shop a fit?)

- What do you sell that's made from ingredients you buy? Roughly how many items on the menu?
- Which till system do you use, and can it export item sales? (Square, Toast, Clover and most others can.)
- How do you order today, and how often do you run out or throw things away?
- How many staff, and how do you do the schedule?
- Who would use it day to day, and on what device?

Objections and honest answers

They say	You say
"My till already does inventory."	"Most track items sold, not the ingredients inside them. This works out what each drink used, what to reorder from which supplier, and what went missing."
"We use spreadsheets."	"This keeps a live Excel copy for you, but does the arithmetic after every sale, delivery and count, so nobody has to."
"There are bigger products for this."	"Yes, built for bigger operations and priced like it. This is made for one or two shops: simple, quick to set up, and your data stays yours in Excel."
"I don't have time to set it up."	"You fill in a template with your menu and suppliers; we load it and train your team in one session."
"Is my data safe?"	"Your shop runs on its own, separate from every other customer, over HTTPS. Everyone has their own login, it's backed up daily, and you can download everything any time."
"What about allergies?"	"It lists the allergens in every drink from its recipe, so staff can answer quickly. It doesn't know about shared blenders, so it supports your allergy procedure; it doesn't replace it."
"It's too expensive."	Use the pilot's real numbers: what the shop saved in waste and stock-outs each month against the monthly fee.

7 Recruit and train a salesperson

Who to look for

Someone who knows the local café and restaurant scene (a former manager, a supplier rep, a hospitality consultant), is comfortable walking in to introduce themselves, and listens more than they talk.

How to pay them

- **Commission-only** (a share of each new customer's setup fee and first months of subscription) costs nothing until they sell; a **small base plus commission** attracts steadier people.

- Pay commission when the **customer pays**, and take it back if the customer cancels within the first 60–90 days.
- Check whether they're a contractor or an employee where you are (the rules matter for tax), and put it in a written agreement.

Rules of engagement (write them down)

- Sell only what's on the price sheet; no discounts or custom features without you.
- No promised start dates; you confirm onboarding dates.
- Use the allergen wording above; never say a drink is "allergen-free".
- They find, qualify, demo and sign; **you** set up the shop and train it. Handoff: contact, till system, menu size, locations, pain points, hoped-for start date.

Two-week training plan

When	What
Day 1	Read the brochure, proposal and case study. Use the demo as staff and as manager, following both guides.
Day 2	Take the **Staff** and **Manager knowledge checks**; pass both (10/12 and 13/15). Go over wrong answers together.
Days 3–5	Shadow at least two of your demos. Learn the qualifying questions and the 10-minute script.
Week 2	Role-play every objection with you. Give two demos while you watch, with feedback after each. Then go solo.
Every week	15-minute check-in: demos given, pilots started, customers signed, what shops asked for.

Launch checklist

1. Business basics

- [ ] Name checked (trademark, .com)
- [ ] Business registered; tax ID
- [ ] Business bank account and bookkeeping
- [ ] Insurance: liability, E&O, cyber
- [ ] Invoicing with monthly billing

2. Domain and server

- [ ] Domain bought; auto-renew, lock, 2FA
- [ ] 2 GB server secured (SSH keys, firewall, updates)
- [ ] DNS: demo and * records
- [ ] demo.yourbrand.com live over HTTPS
- [ ] Owner and demo logins created
- [ ] Nightly demo reset in cron
- [ ] Snapshots, weekly backup download, uptime monitor
- [ ] Business email on the domain

3. Tested like a customer

- [ ] Every guide task done on phone and tablet
- [ ] Both knowledge checks passed
- [ ] Real till export imported; real menu loaded
- [ ] Backup restored once

4. Pilot

- [ ] Shop chosen and pilot agreement signed
- [ ] Baseline measured before starting
- [ ] 6–8 weeks with weekly check-ins
- [ ] Case study and testimonial written

5. Offer and paperwork

- [ ] Setup and monthly prices decided
- [ ] What's included written down
- [ ] Service agreement, privacy notice
- [ ] Lawyer review done

6. Sales kit

- [ ] Brochure printed with contact details
- [ ] Proposal updated with real results
- [ ] Demo script, questions, objections
- [ ] Pipeline sheet and follow-up emails

7. Salesperson

- [ ] Agreement with commission and rules
- [ ] Both knowledge checks passed
- [ ] Two supervised demos given
- [ ] Weekly check-in booked